

Main

Report Name (Org_Country_Year_Report Type)

ILRI_Kenya_2022-23_3-month report

Fellowship Organization

International Livestock Research Institute (ILRI)

Fellowship City

Nairobi

Fellowship Country

Kenya

Fellowship Start Date

08/22/2022

Anticipated Fellowship End Date

08/22/2023

What is your fellowship title/role?

Communication Specialist

What are your primary responsibilities?

Support ILRI communications team:

- Working with the CKM team to write blogs, articles and media releases
- Support the development of multimedia products such as videos, podcasts and other digital media
- Work with the social media team to develop engaging social media around events, campaigns or new releases
- Support work of media and public awareness including developing a contact mailing list of journalists, e-letter and other media monitoring system

I receive adequate direction and support to perform my fellowship responsibilities.

Neutral

Did you receive any sort of orientation, handover or onboarding when you started your fellowship?

Somewhat

Please describe your orientation/onboarding and note who handled it.

Prior to Arrival -

We had several meetings prior to arrival talking about travel, housing, work, and immigration. We joined a few meetings discussing The Boma Podcast, which is one of our main responsibilities. We also had meetings with the previous year's fellows to discuss work culture like what to wear in the office as well as living in Nairobi as a young person generally.

Upon arrival -

Two onsite people, one of them a previous PiAf fellow, helped us adjust, introducing us to the office and Nairobi (more detail later). CapDev took charge of our visa situation.

If you did not receive any kind of orientation, what information or guidance were you provided at the start of your fellowship?
Describe a representative day at work.

After a 30-60 minute Bolt/Uber ride to the office, depending on traffic, I arrive and begin work at 9 am. I answer emails, work on blogs and have several meetings about the podcast or future events. We normally eat lunch at 12:30 pm at the cafeteria and go for a walk after. I leave work at 5 pm and take a uber back to where I stay, which is another 45-75 minute Bolt/Uber ride.

On average, how many hours per week do you work?

40

How would you describe your effectiveness in your fellowship post so far?

Neutral

Please briefly describe 1-2 specific projects that you have undertaken or accomplishments you have made so far.

- Produced One Health and gender in climate blogs, podcasts and other multimedia products and disseminating via social media for the International Livestock Research Institute (ILRI) and the Consortium of International Agriculture Research Centers (CGIAR) with the goal to improve food security and reduce poverty in developing countries
- Planned media coverage with 15 journalists for Farmer's Field Day, a community teaching event for 250+ farmers in Machakos County, Kenya with various partners, stakeholders, and donors
- Initiated company-wide TikTok action plan following an audit and presentation on successful accounts
- Investigated the socioeconomic benefits to livestock by traveling to Lwak, Kenya and interviewing households participating in a field study on chickens and child nutrition

What is your organization's work culture like?
What is your office environment like? Please comment on the size and structure of the office(s) where you do most of your work.

A desk in the open space of the info centre/library where the communications team works. The other team members are in offices in the building. There is also good natural lighting, water, and an office kitchen with a microwave and sink. The bathroom is a minute walk away. Other research fellows study in the library.

To whom do you report?

Team leader, media and communications

We work closely with him. He gives us assignments and everything we do passes through him several times. For example, for blogs, he assigns us the topic, edits and provides feedback for the first drafts, and approves publishing.

Have you had an initial check-in with your supervisor to set up a work plan and to set goals for your work during your fellowship year?

No

Was this meeting helpful in understanding your role and setting goals for your fellowship year?

Please explain why you have not met with your supervisor and if you have plans to do so going forward.

All of our meetings have been with both Madison and I. Have not had the chance to meet with my supervisor individually, but I plan on requesting one too.

Please briefly indicate 3-5 professional goals you have for the rest of your fellowship year. Your professional goals should align with your work plan.

- Learn how to responsibly engage with different people and cultures within the international development sector while on the African continent and in the field.
- Be introduced and work with many different levels and sectors within ILRI from donors to field assistants, gender to One Health, to form deep professional connections on the continent and have a better grasp on what I'd like to focus on in the future.
- To refine my ability to communicate science to the general public, making sure that information reaches and impacts the communities most affected and vulnerable to climate change.

How often do you check in with your supervisor?

Daily

Have you had an opportunity to travel for work so far?

Yes

Describe this travel opportunity. Include location(s) and a brief description of the purpose of the trip(s).

I have travelled by car three times to Machakos County to ILRI's Kapiti Research Station and Wildlife Conservancy to accompany journalists, organize, and report on events. Two events were community outreach events for World Rabies Day and a farmer's field day. The third event was to welcome the Prince of Norway. I have also travelled to Kisumu County for a day trip by plane. We took a company car from the airport and accompanied another communications team member and a researcher to several rural households in Lwak, interviewing them on a poultry study they participated in.

I feel adequately prepared for my position's professional responsibilities.

Agree

Please briefly explain your response.

From previous professional and personal experience, I'm well-equipped to write blogs, create TikToks, and produce podcasts. Times, where I have difficulty, are when I'm not given ample instruction for how tasks must be completed at ILRI. Contrary to my previous work experience at NGOs and nonprofits, ILRI is much larger and extremely bureaucratic, yet the communications team is still small. There have been times when I haven't gotten the answers I needed despite reaching out until it is too late. There have also been times when I've been given large responsibilities that my supervisor is not well-equipped to support because the project is out of his usual jurisdiction as a comms person. For example, I was told to be in charge of the ILRI tent where 200+ rural farmers who only speak the local language would pass through. Luckily, on the day of, local staff members took my place.

Life at Fellowship Site

How did you travel to your host country and site? Please be specific

I flew direct on Kenya Airways from JFK to NBO. The travel consultancy ILRI uses, Charleston Travel gave me flight options, then booked my flight and a return flight for December for Visa purposes that have since been cancelled. My round-trip tickets were \$1025 and paid for by ILRI.

What kind of visa/ permit do you have or applied for?

Single Entry Tourist Visa (second extension) and I have applied for a Student Pass

How did you obtain (or are obtaining) your visa or permit?

Before arrival I applied online through evisa, for extensions once in country online eFNS with someone connected to ILRI bringing my passport to immigration for an updated stamp

Did you apply for and receive your visa / permit before heading to your host country or after arriving?

Before arriving

What costs were associated with obtaining your visa or permit?

\$51

Did you pay the visa / permit costs or were they covered by your organization?

placeholder

Are you still having challenges obtaining your visa/ permit?

Yes

If yes, please explain further

We are the first fellows to be at ILRI for the full 12 months. Previously, Tim was never on campus, and the duration of a tourist visa was sufficient for Brenda and Elliot. Therefore, prior to arriving, we asked what the visa procedure was and was told to apply for a single-entry tourist visa. Two weeks into work, we received an email from the CapDev team at ILRI asking about our arrival, despite meeting one of the team members on our first day of work. They had no idea when we were arriving. The miscommunication between the ILRI's CKM team and CapDev occurred because CapDev manages all the fellows and the onboarding procedure for fellows is different than normal staff members. We were told after arriving that we should have applied for a business visa and that we needed a police clearance (which for the state of New York requires in-person fingerprinting) after arriving. I also found out that at the airport, I was only given 1 month instead of 3 months on a tourist visa. Luckily, I was able to receive a police clearance from Medford Police Station near my university by email, otherwise, CapDev was going to request for me to return home and obtain one. We have submitted our student pass applications, but in the meantime, I have extended my tourist visa for the second time despite being told that doing so is risky. We've had many meetings where the CapDev team has blamed this on us and the conversations have felt a bit hostile/condescending, and this miscommunication has made the transition much harder. It is my first time living in another country on my own, so I have now learned a lot from this experience that will help guide me in the future but simple conversations or questions properly answered would have made this less painful and avoidable. On a less stressful but still disappointing note, without a resident card, leaving the country to explore others and paying park fees have been pushed back to next year to save on paying the re-entry and non-resident fees. We are fortunate with our stipend and because Kenya is a large country with many options, so we have still been travelling within the country.

g) Do you have any suggestions to help future Fellows navigate the visa / permit application process?

David now understands and I also plan on informing the next fellows of everything they have to do. Like how once arriving, we let Asa and Bifra know that they should get a police clearance.

What vaccinations were you required to obtain prior to your departure? How much did your vaccinations cost? Did you get a yellow fever vaccination?

I needed to receive a Typhoid and Yellow Fever vaccine. I went to a clinic in New York City that offered an 8% discount if I paid in cash. Yellow Fever was \$195, Typhoid was \$85, and there was a small fee for the consultation. It was easy to book an appointment, and there were a lot of availabilities. This is the website: <https://www.travelclinicny.com/>

I'm going to get my rabies vaccination here though. I avoided it in the US because it's so expensive, but I've been living in fear ever since Princeton's travel nurse spoke at orientation. Everyone says it's fine, but ILRI sent me out into the field for World Rabies Day where 200+ dogs and cats were getting vaccinated and I'm unvaccinated! So on the side of precaution, I will get my rabies vaccination.

How was your arrival and first week in your host country? Any improvements that could streamline the assimilation process for future Fellows?

The arrival was very smooth. I bought a Safaricom SIM card at the airport after asking the person picking me up which carrier was best. I'm glad they told me Safaricom because I need it for M-PESA. An ILRI car picked me up right when I arrived at the airport and drove me to ILRI where I stayed at the ILRI Hostel for my first three days. I arrived on a Sunday, but my supervisor was still very responsive, ensuring that I would make it to ILRI. ILRI has water coolers, so I had no stomach problems. The next day, my supervisor met us outside the Hostel and took us to breakfast and around ILRI. He also took us to the closest mall to set up M-PESA. During those three days on campus, we also booked an Airbnb for the first month and found an apartment for the rest of the year. We booked the Airbnb last minute because of the election, we didn't want to make a deposit while we were in the US in case our arrival was delayed. Because of these factors, it was a bit expensive and not the best quality apartment, especially for what we were paying. I would recommend future fellows use the expat housing Facebook groups and reach out to previous fellows or people they know in Nairobi. We found our place through one of Maddy's mutual friends. I will happily volunteer as a contact.

Is housing provided by and/or paid for by your organization? Please explain.

No, I pay for it myself with my stipend.

Do you live in a location that is more urban or rural?

Very Urban

Please describe your living environment

I live in a duplex penthouse apartment in Kileleshwa across the Arboretum. It has 24/7 security and a pool. We have a terrace/roof and a balcony. It is on a fairly busy, main road. We have cool birds outside our balcony and window.

How do you typically travel between your home and your work? How much does your daily transportation cost and how long is your commute?

I normally take a Bolt or Uber to and from work. Normally the commute is 30 minutes to 75 minutes depending on the traffic and the route the driver takes. Maddy and I usually split the rides, so I spend about 600Ksh a day or \$4.90.

If you live in a more rural area, what are the closest urban areas you can travel to for shopping, airport, larger medical centers, etc.?

N/A

How is the weather in your host country? What season are you presently in?

Currently in short rains, but it is slowly getting warmer. According to my supervisor, it is colder than usual but it feels very temperate. The average temperature for this month was high of 25 degrees Celsius and low of 14 degrees Celsius.

What is the appropriate clothing for work and outside of work at your fellowship post and in your community in general?

For work, I dress business casual but casual is okay. Outside work, I usually wear pants and show less skin than I would in the States.

How have you been spending your free time?

I have been spending my free time calling friends and other fellows, going out to eat or going to shopping markets with friends, going to an Afro Dance class, going to church/bible study, and learning the guitar from one of my flatmates. There is a lot of opportunity to try new things and meet new people. The other day I went to a 7:30 am spin class with Maddy, but I did not think it was fun. Everyone was really nice though!

I've been able to successfully navigate my personal/social life both back at home and at my fellowship post.

Disagree

Please briefly explain your response below.

I think I'm judging myself a bit harshly here because I don't think I'm doing a terrible job navigating this, but I think I'm not doing as well as I hoped. It has been difficult being present in Nairobi, keeping up with the other PiAf fellows on the continent, and remaining in contact with my friends and family back home. While trying to have experiences and build a community here, I feel a bit of guilt for not reaching out as often to other fellows and people back home. I also feel like my personal time has suffered trying to juggle it all. A lot of this has to do with me not being a student for the first time and trying to learn how to be an adult and not so much being in Nairobi while being across the world certainly is a factor. I just try to keep up with it all but put most of my energy into where I currently am.

Would you say you live and work in a safe area?

I live in a safe area. Usually, my only concerns are pickpocketing, traffic accidents, and not feeling like my privacy is being respected by men. At work, it is very safe. I only had one man from another team try to contact me after work hours for a week, but then he stopped.

What precautions do you take to ensure your safety?

I'm extra cautious when I walk around alone and cross the street. I never walk out at night. I always put on my seatbelt in cars that have working seatbelts. In terms of unwanted pursuits by men, I work in an extremely male-dominated work environment, so I usually discuss things with my friends who are women. I usually just block contacts, and that is enough. Maddy has been a huge support for me.

What has been your experience with crime so far? (Please note that any security or safety concerns or incidents should be reported directly to PiAf staff per PiAf safety and security protocol.)

I have never felt unsafe, but I have witnessed a few incidents. I had an acquaintance have his phone stolen at a party, then have only the Kenyans searched but none of the expats, so I was not searched. A man in our hostel room in Diani was kicked out by another woman in our room for acting inappropriately. I also witnessed a traffic accident but was not involved.

Describe the incidence of crime and the general security situation within your city/town. Could you recommend specific areas future Fellows might consider for safe housing? What about areas that should be avoided?

I think traffic accidents and pickpocketing/robbery is frequent. I would recommend staying in areas where other fellows have lived, with other people, and places where there is security. Honestly, and sadly, I'm really grateful for my male flatmates/friends. They help me a lot when we are walking around the city, out at night, or travelling.

Please refer back to the goals you set for yourself before orientation. Are you working towards these goals? Have you met any of them? Changed any of them? Please explain.

I still can't access my VITALS, so I don't have access to my goals. I think there is a lot on my mind, and I have found some success and have also changed some goals. I have learned so much about Kenyan culture, and have found a lot of similarities between Kenyan culture and my Chinese American Culture. Before starting work at ILRI, I was worried that as a native New Yorker, I wouldn't be able to relate to agriculture development. However, being here, I've been reminded that my grandfather immigrated to the States from a fishing village in Southern China. I've been able to share my family history and bond over fried fish with my Kenyan coworkers! I have also made many connections while here, both professionally and personally. My goal has shifted to finding community, which has been difficult here because Nairobi is such a transient city. In terms of what's next for me, I'm a bit confused. I think my skills are well-suited for communications, but I don't think it's my passion. I'm now working on crafting a professional goal for this year! But every day, I am pushed and challenged by the people I meet, work with, and live with. For more personal goals, I have yet to learn how to cook Kenyan food, but I have been invited to two weddings (unsure if I can actually attend though!)

Do you have any frustrations with your living arrangements, your work or your life outside of work?

I think a lot of the frustrations I'm feeling are a combination of many things and not the fellowship itself. When I signed the PiAf contract, I signed it without hesitation and somewhat naively. I wouldn't go back and change anything, but what I have learned is that there are many things I should have considered and asked questions about, which I plan to do in the future. For example, I should have asked more questions about financing, housing, the work itself, being East Asian in Africa, visa status, etc. I think it has been difficult at ILRI because communications, as said earlier, is not my passion. Furthermore, David is so kind, but for me, he is not a good manager because his expertise is in media and communications. In a very male-dominated setting, I don't feel like I have a mentor here. It is hard to feel like I'm floating and to go to people my age, experiencing the same things (like Maddy), for advice. It's hard to know what I want for the future without proper guidance and feedback in the present. Also, Maddy and I are often grouped together at work, but we want different things, have different goals, and are different people. I'm going to propose that our meetings with David be one-on-one, rather than in a group. I think it will make a big difference. It will also provide space to talk about our goals for the year and what we want out of this fellowship!

The commute and traffic to and from work, but it is out of my control!

Oh and there have also been so many mosquitoes lately, and mosquitoes love me more than they love the average person. I keep getting bit on the face! Those mosquitoes that somehow get into my net have been so frustrating! But I have now learned to tuck in my net under the mattress! Just a silly frustration.

Has there been anything that you have needed but have not been able to locate or acquire?

Not anything I need! Nairobi has more than enough for what I need and want.

How have you dealt with "culture shock"?

Some instances of culture shock have been a bit funny like one time we went to church and it ended up being five hours. I've been going to church all my life, but African church is different!

On a more serious note, another thing I was not prepared for was how Chinese people are perceived in Kenya. In my experience, most Kenyans are not happy about Chinese development in Africa. Luckily for me, I speak English, so most Kenyans are just curious about where I'm from. Also, I don't really look ethnically Chinese because I'm not entirely and also genetics, so usually, Kenyans don't think I am. I do, however, get confronted with my race every day. I get asked if I'm Filipino (which people ask in the states), Korean, Japanese, Chinese,

Burmese, everything, etc. There have been a few instances where someone has told me I'm Indian despite there being so many Kenyan Indians. Depending on my mood, I share why I look the way I do but speak English. It gets harder when I'm in a group of international folks where everyone stands out, but I'm the one that gets picked on. Sometimes there is unwanted hair touching and photo taking without my permission.

What about your experience thus far has been the most...surprising?

The most surprising thing has been how international the office is, and by international, I mean white. At work, I don't interact with Kenyans as much as I thought. I knew I was going to look different than most everybody, but even at an international organization, I'm almost always the only Asian, specifically East Asian woman, in the room. Also that our office is very male-dominated.

What about your experience thus far has been the most...challenging?

I think the hardest thing has been learning how to adult and with that comes starting my first job, moving to a new place, budgeting, making adult friends, etc. This is the first time in my life that I haven't been a student, and it feels like a lot of life changes at once. I'm sure living in a new country that I've never been to before does make things a little bit more challenging, but I'm ageing up and most problems would arise no matter where I was living. I have a less flexible schedule than I did in school and everyone else is also busy. Nairobi is a very transient city, and I feel like even though I'm meeting so many people, it's hard to make deep connections. The community that I crave is also what I miss the most from back home--my family, friends, and Asian American groups. I'm not looking to replicate that exact community here, that's not what I want, but I do miss it. As I'm slowly creating a community that understands me-- not without difficulty--it's a bit lonely even though I'm always surrounded by people.

What are the top 3 things you miss the most from your home country or the U.S.?

- My mom's and dad's cooking
- Sleeping without a mosquito net
- The NYC subway

What are the top 3 things about life in your host country that beat out life in your home country or the U.S.?

- Weather
- Uber prices
- The bananas

How is your stipend being paid?

Monthly, in US dollars, to a US account.

How are you receiving your stipend funds?

ACH

Did you raise funds to cover part of your fellowship expenses?

I have been using savings.

Please list any additional one-time or infrequent expenses not included in your monthly budget below.

Monthly Budget

Rent	Utilities	Furnishings	Phone	Home Security	Internet
\$350.00	\$0.00	\$0.00	\$15.00	\$0.00	\$0.00
Transportation	Fitness	Entertainment	Groceries	House Cleaning	Eating Out
\$80.00	\$15.00	\$20.00	\$100.00	\$0.00	\$300.00
Medications	Additional Health Insurance	Travel	Laundry	Other	Total Monthly Budget (Minus Entertainment & Travel)
\$0.00	\$0.00	\$399.98	\$0.00	\$0.00	860.00
Specify "Other"					

Final Thoughts

PiAf's orientation was sufficient in preparing me to transition into my fellowship.

Neutral

Please briefly explain your response about Orientation.

There was so much information given but once on the continent, there seemed to be confusion on how to access resources. There is limited time, so it would have been helpful to have the information be given in prerecorded videos ahead of time., then use the sessions more as workshops and interacting with alumni. Rather than having alumni teach, I think I wanted to hear more instances when they used insurance or Konterra. A lot of information lost that would have been gained through interacting with alumni may have been due to the hybrid nature of our year, but I think we learned a lot of information multiple times. An exercise where we actually use the platforms would be extremely helpful as well. For example, pretending to call because there was an accident.

Is there anything in particular that PiAf could cover at orientation that would have better prepared you for your fellowship post? Please specify.

I mentioned some ideas above. I think the regional meet-ups should have been mentioned, especially things that we are paying for ourselves. Also, more details on our Mid-Year Retreat or at least when we would find out about it. Lastly, if post-orientation, there was an easier way to access the alumni network to see who lives near us in the US and who still lives on the continent in our country. It was only because I hosted the Instagram takeover that I learned of people connected to the PiAf network and PiAf alumni living in Nairobi.

As we plan the upcoming PiAf Retreat, we hope to incorporate some Fellow suggestions into our programming. What are some topics or sessions you would like to see at the Retreat? (We appreciate your feedback however, we may not be able to accommodate all suggestions or requests this year.)

What's next after PiAf? How can we utilize the PiAf Alumni Network? How can we support each other, our fellow cohort, better? What have we learned to share with the next cohort of PiAf fellows?